

The City of Refuge

Rudolph Fisher · 1925

First published: The Atlantic Monthly, Feb 1925

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_New_Negro/The_City_of_Refuge (revision 15183088), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The City of Refuge suggest about the Great Migration?
- What does The City of Refuge suggest about hope and exploitation?
- What does The City of Refuge suggest about urban identity?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The City of Refuge	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*the Great Migration* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The City of Refuge

Focus: Harlem as promised refuge and trap

Content note (racial slurs in dialogue, drugs, violence): Sensitive content: Racial slurs in dialogue; drugs; violence. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes racial slurs in dialogue; drugs; violence.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

King Solomon Gillis flees North Carolina after shooting a white man and arrives in Harlem, amazed to see a Black policeman. He trusts Mouse Uggam, a fellow Southerner, who uses him to sell drugs. When the police come for him, Gillis fights, then sees the Black officer, and gives himself up with something exultant in his face.

Background: Published in The Atlantic Monthly in February 1925 and reprinted in The New Negro; Harlem was the destination of many in the Great Migration.

Significance: A key Harlem Renaissance story about the Great Migration.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: What would a 'city of refuge' mean to someone escaping danger? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes racial slurs in dialogue; drugs; violence.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are spokesman, singsong, crouched, purchases, mornings. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "Inside, the spokesman snuffled, gave his shoulders a queer little hunch, and asked, "Can you fix us up, buddy?"" In this sentence it means: the person who did most of the talking. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The City of Refuge would have known. Published in The Atlantic Monthly in February 1925 and reprinted in The New Negro; Harlem was the destination of many in the Great Migration. Why does this story matter? A key Harlem Renaissance story about the Great Migration. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for setting.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "Uggam stepped over and opened the door." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to Harlem as promised refuge and trap? I circle "singsong", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find setting, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for setting.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of setting. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *Uggam stepped over and opened the door. King Solomon's apprehensive eyes saw framed therein, instead of a gigantic officer, calling for him, a little blot of a creature, quite black against even the darkness of the hallway, except for a dirty, wide-striped silk shirt, collarless, with the sleeves rolled up. "Ah hahve bill fo' Mr. Gillis." A high, strongly accented Jamaican voice, with its characteristic singsong intonation, interrupted King Solomon's sigh of relief.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Setting, Irony, Characterization: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The City of Refuge develops the idea of Harlem as promised refuge and trap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to the Great Migration? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about Harlem as promised refuge and trap, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes Harlem as promised refuge and trap. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
spokesman (noun)	the person who did most of the talking	*Inside, the spokesman snuffled, gave his shoulders a queer little hunch, and asked, "Can you fix us up, buddy?"*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
singsong (noun)	a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation	*A high, strongly accented Jamaican voice, with its characteristic singsong intonation, interrupted King Solomon's sigh of relief.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
crouched (verb)	bend one's back forward from the waist on down	*Yet most of the vehicles that leaped or crouched at his bidding carried white passengers.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
purchases (noun)	the acquisition of something for payment	*The mysterious thing about it was that their purchases totalled little more than those of the original three or four.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
mornings (noun)	the time period between dawn and noon	*Tony had tested him, as he always tested a new man, by apparently leaving him alone in charge for two or three mornings.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
meditating (verb)	reflect deeply on a subject	*King Solomon Gillis sat meditating in a room half the size of his hencoop back home, with a single window opening into an airshaft.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
gratefully (adverb)	with appreciation; in a grateful manner	*King Solomon located and gratefully extended a slip of paper.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
shifting (verb)	changing	*Patronage had a queer way of shifting itself in Harlem.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
repeatedly (adverb)	several time	*Why should strangers leave their own neighborhoods and repeatedly come to him for a yeast cake or a loaf of bread?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
rewarded (verb)	given something good in return	*In the tumult of merriment that rewarded the entertainer's most recent and daring effort, one of these men, with a word to the other, came over and took the vacant chair beside Gillis.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What would a 'city of refuge' mean to someone escaping danger?
2. Where does setting appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with the Great Migration?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why did Gillis leave North Carolina? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He shot a white man
2. What amazes Gillis in Harlem? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A Black policeman directing white drivers
3. Who befriends and exploits him? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Mouse Uggam
4. What is Gillis unknowingly selling? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Drugs
5. What does Gillis do at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Surrenders when he sees the Black officer
6. Retell the three most important events of "The City of Refuge" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: King Solomon Gillis flees North Carolina after shooting a white man and arrives in Harlem, amazed to see a Black policeman. He trusts Mouse Uggam, a fellow Southerner, who uses him to sell drugs. When the police come for him, Gillis fights, then sees the Black officer, and gives himself up with something exultant in his face.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The City of Refuge"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The City of Refuge" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "Inside, the spokesman snuffled, gave his shoulders a queer little hunch, and asked, "Can you fix us up, buddy?"" What does "spokesman" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: spokesman: the person who did most of the talking.
10. Reread: "A high, strongly accented Jamaican voice, with its characteristic singsong intonation, interrupted King Solomon's sigh of relief." What does "singsong" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: singsong: a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The City of Refuge" suggest about Harlem as promised refuge and trap? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A key Harlem Renaissance story about the Great Migration.

2. Find one example of setting in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
3. How does the irony in this story shape what we understand about Harlem as promised refuge and trap? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
4. In the passage that begins “Uggam stepped over and opened the door.”, why might Fisher have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The City of Refuge”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: King Solomon Gillis flees North Carolina after shooting a white man and arrives in Harlem, amazed to see a Black policeman. He trusts Mouse Uggam, a fellow Southerner, who uses him to sell drugs. When the police come for him, Gillis fights, then sees the Black officer, and gives himself up with…
6. As the opening story, what does “The City of Refuge” set up that the rest of The City of Refuge will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What would a 'city of refuge' mean to someone escaping danger?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with the Great Migration? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
10. Background: Published in The Atlantic Monthly in February 1925 and reprinted in The New Negro; Harlem was the destination of many in the Great Migration. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A key Harlem Renaissance story about the Great Migration.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The City of Refuge” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about Harlem as promised refuge and trap? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The City of Refuge”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to hope and exploitation: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Fisher need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the setting in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “The City of Refuge” treats Harlem as promised refuge and trap with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The City of Refuge see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve the Great Migration? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Harlem as promised refuge and trap? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Rudolph Fisher about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. Why did Gillis leave North Carolina?
   A. His family moved
   B. He wanted college
   C. He shot a white man
   D. He was drafted
2. What amazes Gillis in Harlem?
   A. Tall buildings only
   B. The river
   C. The subway
   D. A Black policeman directing white drivers
3. Who befriends and exploits him?
   A. A preacher
   B. Tony Gabrielli

C. Mouse Uggam

D. Uncle Ezra

4. What is Gillis unknowingly selling?

A. Lottery tickets

B. Stolen jewelry

C. Liquor

D. Drugs

5. What does Gillis do at the end?

A. Returns south

B. Escapes

C. Surrenders when he sees the Black officer

D. Kills Mouse

6. In the line “Inside, the spokesman snuffled, gave his shoulders a queer little hunch, and asked, “Can you fix us up, buddy?””, what does “spokesman” most nearly mean?

A. a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation

B. bend one's back forward from the waist on down

C. the acquisition of something for payment

D. the person who did most of the talking

7. In the line “A high, strongly accented Jamaican voice, with its characteristic singsong intonation, interrupted King Solomon's sigh of relief.”, what does “singsong” most nearly mean?

A. the person who did most of the talking

B. the acquisition of something for payment

C. bend one's back forward from the waist on down

D. a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation

Answer key: 1. C (He shot a white man); 2. D (A Black policeman directing white drivers); 3. C (Mouse Uggam); 4. D (Drugs); 5. C (Surrenders when he sees the Black officer); 6. D (the person who did most of the talking); 7. D (a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The City of Refuge,” how does Fisher show Harlem as promised refuge and trap? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The City of Refuge, how does Fisher develop the idea of Harlem as promised refuge and trap? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The City of Refuge develops the idea of Harlem as promised refuge and trap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The City of Refuge (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of Harlem as promised refuge and trap. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The City of Refuge suggests about Harlem as promised refuge and trap. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's setting and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Rudolph Fisher uses setting in The City of Refuge to complicate the reader's understanding of Harlem as promised refuge and trap. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The City of Refuge within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of Harlem as promised refuge and trap responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The City of Refuge alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of Harlem as promised refuge and trap follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The City of Refuge and its treatment of Harlem as promised refuge and trap. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's setting and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The City of Refuge as evidence for a larger claim about Harlem as promised refuge and trap in The City of Refuge. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The City of Refuge as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of Harlem as

promised refuge and trap. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The City of Refuge.

SAT-style questions

1. *Yet most of the vehicles that leaped or crouched at his bidding carried white passengers.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “crouched” most nearly mean?

   A. changing

   B. several time

   C. given something good in return

   D. bend one's back forward from the waist on down

2. *Uggam stepped over and opened the door. King Solomon's apprehensive eyes saw framed therein, instead of a gigantic officer, calling for him, a little blot of a creature, quite black against even the darkness of the hallway, except for a dirty, wide-striped silk shirt, collarless, with the sleeves rolled up. “Ah hahve bill fo' Mr. Gillis.” A high, strongly accented Jamaican voice, with its characteristic singsong intonation, interrupted King Solomon's sigh of relief.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The City of Refuge”?

   A. A reversal that punishes a change of heart

   B. Harlem as promised refuge and trap

   C. A story so convincing it becomes real

   D. Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve

SAT key: 1. D (bend one's back forward from the waist on down); 2. B (Harlem as promised refuge and trap)

Whole-book test

The City of Refuge: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Why did Gillis leave North Carolina?
   A. His family moved
   B. He wanted college
   C. He shot a white man
   D. He was drafted
2. What amazes Gillis in Harlem?
   A. Tall buildings only
   B. The river
   C. The subway
   D. A Black policeman directing white drivers
3. Who befriends and exploits him?
   A. A preacher
   B. Tony Gabrielli
   C. Mouse Uggam
   D. Uncle Ezra
4. What is Gillis unknowingly selling?
   A. Lottery tickets
   B. Stolen jewelry
   C. Liquor
   D. Drugs
5. What does Gillis do at the end?
   A. Returns south
   B. Escapes
   C. Surrenders when he sees the Black officer
   D. Kills Mouse
6. In the line “Inside, the spokesman snuffled, gave his shoulders a queer little hunch, and asked, “Can you fix us up, buddy?””, what does “spokesman” most nearly mean?
   A. a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation
   B. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
   C. the acquisition of something for payment
   D. the person who did most of the talking

7. In the line “A high, strongly accented Jamaican voice, with its characteristic singsong intonation, interrupted King Solomon's sigh of relief.”, what does “singsong” most nearly mean?
   A. the person who did most of the talking
   B. the acquisition of something for payment
   C. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
   D. a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation
8. As used in the story (“Inside, the spokesman snuffled, gave his shoulders a queer little hunch, and asked, “Can you fix us up, buddy?””), what does “spokesman” mean?
   A. the person who did most of the talking
   B. the time period between dawn and noon
   C. changing
   D. a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation
9. As used in the story (“A high, strongly accented Jamaican voice, with its characteristic singsong intonation, interrupted King Solomon's sigh of relief.”), what does “singsong” mean?
   A. reflect deeply on a subject
   B. a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation
   C. several time
   D. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
10. As used in the story (“Yet most of the vehicles that leaped or crouched at his bidding carried white passengers.”), what does “crouched” mean?
    A. with appreciation; in a grateful manner
    B. given something good in return
    C. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
    D. the acquisition of something for payment
11. As used in the story (“The mysterious thing about it was that their purchases totalled little more than those of the original three or four.”), what does “purchases” mean?
    A. changing
    B. the person who did most of the talking
    C. the time period between dawn and noon
    D. the acquisition of something for payment
12. As used in the story (“Tony had tested him, as he always tested a new man, by apparently leaving him alone in charge for two or three mornings.”), what does “mornings” mean?
    A. the time period between dawn and noon
    B. several time
    C. a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation
    D. reflect deeply on a subject

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how the Great Migration develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how hope and exploitation develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how urban identity develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (the Great Migration, hope and exploitation, urban identity) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (He shot a white man); 2. D (A Black policeman directing white drivers); 3. C (Mouse Uggam); 4. D (Drugs); 5. C (Surrenders when he sees the Black officer); 6. D (the person who did most of the talking); 7. D (a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation); 8. A (the person who did most of the talking); 9. B (a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation); 10. C (bend one's back forward from the waist on down); 11. D (the acquisition of something for payment); 12. A (the time period between dawn and noon)

Essay assignments

Essay: The Great Migration

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The City of Refuge teaches about the Great Migration. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Rudolph Fisher develops the Great Migration in The City of Refuge. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Rudolph Fisher develops the Great Migration across The City of Refuge. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The City of Refuge (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the Great Migration. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the Great Migration in The City of Refuge. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Rudolph Fisher's choices in The City of Refuge (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the Great Migration, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The City of Refuge's treatment of the Great Migration in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the Great Migration in The City of Refuge that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the Great Migration in The City of Refuge. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the Great Migration in The City of Refuge, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the Great Migration in The City of Refuge, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Hope and exploitation

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The City of Refuge teaches about hope and exploitation. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Rudolph Fisher develops hope and exploitation in The City of Refuge. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Rudolph Fisher develops hope and exploitation across The City of Refuge. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The City of Refuge (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of hope and exploitation. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of hope and exploitation in The City of Refuge. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Rudolph Fisher's choices in The City of Refuge (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of hope and exploitation, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The City of Refuge's treatment of hope and exploitation in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on hope and exploitation in The City of Refuge that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on hope and exploitation in The City of Refuge. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about hope and exploitation in The City of Refuge, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on hope and exploitation in The City of Refuge, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Urban identity

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The City of Refuge teaches about urban identity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Rudolph Fisher develops urban identity in The City of Refuge. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Rudolph Fisher develops urban identity across The City of Refuge. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The City of Refuge (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of urban identity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of urban identity in The City of Refuge. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Rudolph Fisher's choices in The City of Refuge (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of urban identity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The City of Refuge's treatment of urban identity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on urban identity in The City of Refuge that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on urban identity in The City of Refuge. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about urban identity in The City of Refuge, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on urban identity in The City of Refuge, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.